The AI chaos beast in your head

$ ELIO STRUYF

$ WHOAMI → HELLO!

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Demo Time · Front Matter CMS

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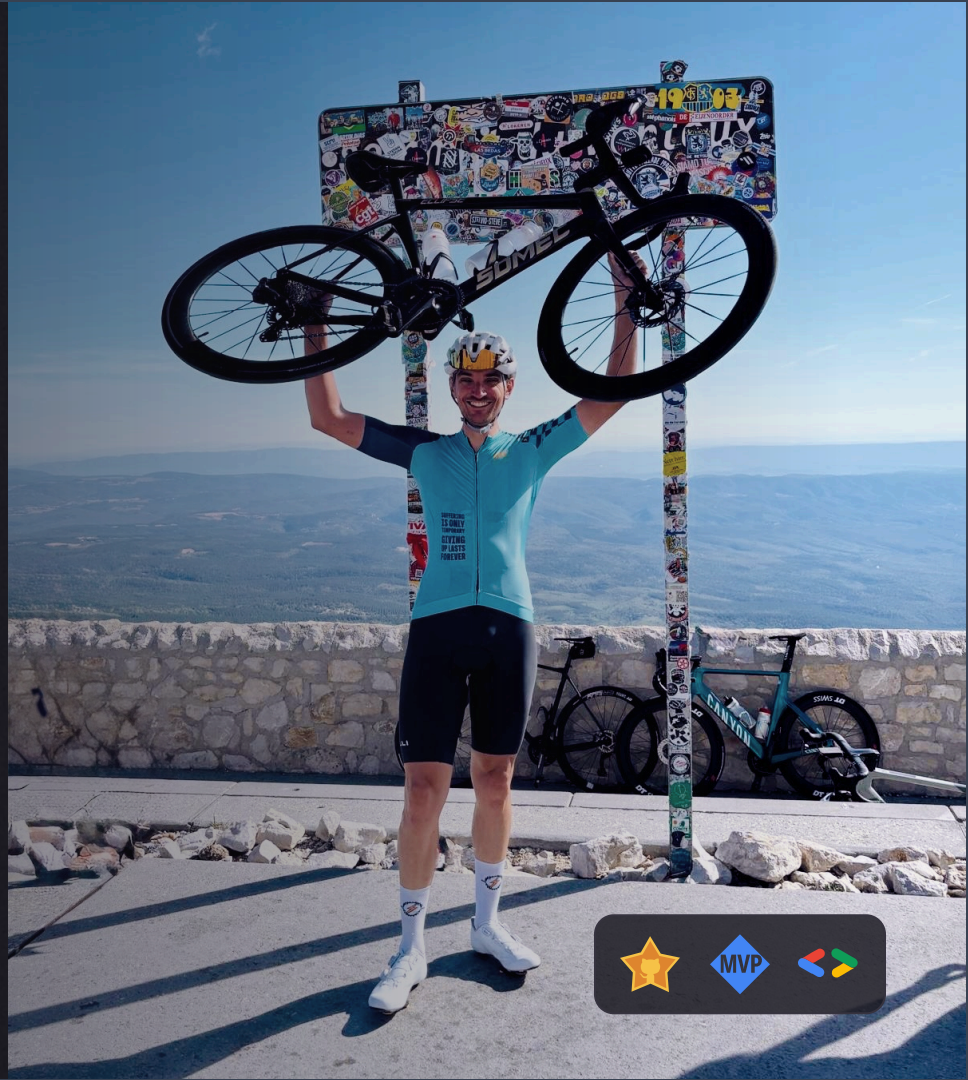

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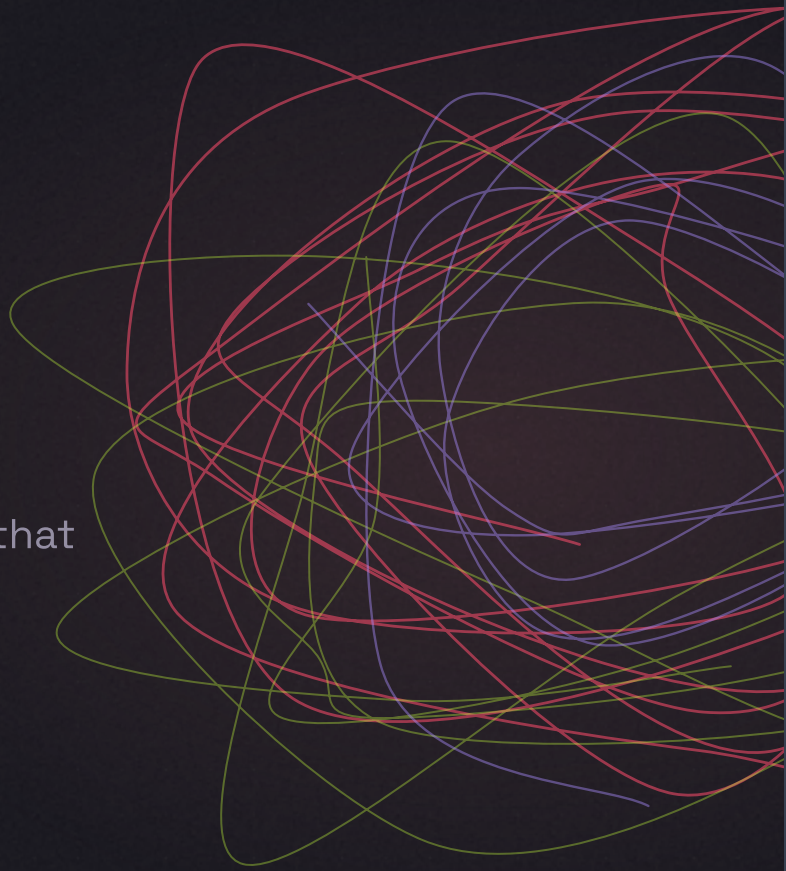
// context switch

AI promised you...

More time. Less boring work. Room for the work that matters.



> Software developers are hired to solve problems and build products.

Writing code is just the implementation tool, not the objective.

What AI was supposed to give us

REPETITIVE, LOW-JUDGMENT WORK

- BOILERPLATE
- CRUD ENDPOINTS
- UNIT TESTS
- DOCS
- MIGRATIONS
- LINT FIXES

AI TAKES IT

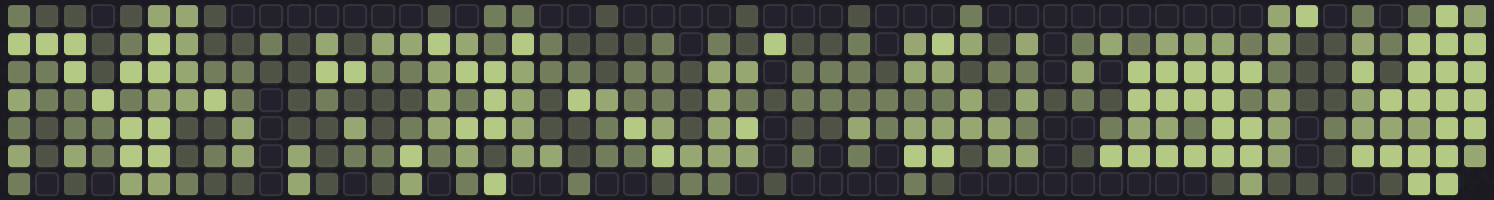
YOU GET THE BANDWIDTH FOR

- **Security**
- **Architecture**
- **Business logic**

Across multiple products, at the exact same time.

Not an AI skeptic

I use AI **every single day**.



GITHUB.COM/ESTRUYF · 6,785 CONTRIBUTIONS IN THE LAST YEAR

This is not a talk against AI.

It's a talk about what it does to ***US***.

// context switch

Three months ago

Is AI quietly taking the joy out of coding, or am I giving it away?

> I don’t enjoy being a developer anymore since AI arrived.

A half-asleep thought, June 2026

BUILT BY HAND

Months of evenings

- Front Matter CMS
- Demo Time
- Built from nothing, evenings and weekends

THE FILTER

Would they even exist?

The slowness was the filter.

If I wasn't willing to give up a year of evenings, it probably wasn't worth building.

The five-minute manager

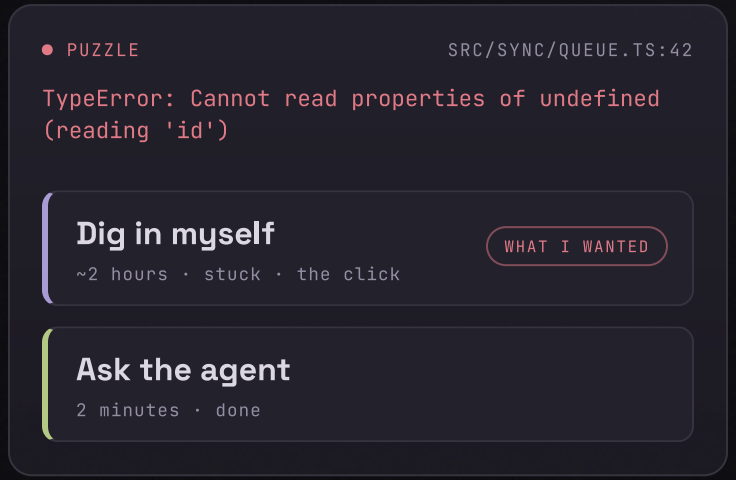
Done. Next. Done. Next.

- No struggle, no getting stuck
- No ”click” moment when it finally works
- No breathing space

The puzzles are still there

I just hand them over.

The low-effort path wins in the moment, even when the high-effort path is the one I actually wanted.



WRITING

The developer

Fought with the problem.

The code came from my own hands.

APPROVING

The maker, the approver

AI hands me the finished thing.

It works. I approve it.

The 10-80-10 method

- **10%** planning, focus, writing the prompt
- **80%** the work, automated with AI
- **10%** after-care: review, test, fix

THE CRAFT

The 80%

Where we found the joy.

Where we pushed ourselves to get better.

WHAT'S LEFT

The 20%

Planning, specs, reviewing, deciding.

The developer moves up a level: judgment, review, decisions.

Nobody asks what that does to our heads.

Are we only good for planning, managing and reviewing?

> AI didn’t take the joy out of coding.
> I gave it away.

The thing that I really was good at ... is less valuable. I know that it's hard to admit.

ThePrimeagen, The PrimeTime on YouTube

Three months later

It turns out I was giving away my focus too.

// context switch

Let me show you my morning

09:00 One task: write the intro of this talk.

0 RUNNING 0 WAITING 0 DONE 0 SWITCHES

me FOCUSED

› Write the intro of my talk.

“The AI chaos beast in your head”

09:04 Just a quick one first.

1 RUNNING 0 WAITING 0 DONE 1 SWITCHES

me — PAUSED

› Write the intro of my talk.

“The AI chaos beast in your head”

pomodoro — RUNNING

› Build a pomodoro timer as a single HTML file. Start, pause and reset, a 25/5 minute cycle, and a sound at the end.

Checking the workspace for a `playground` folder…

09:11 It's working. Why wait? Next one.

2 RUNNING 0 WAITING 0 DONE 2 SWITCHES

me — IDLE 7M

› Write the intro of my talk.

"The AI chaos beast in your head"

pomodoro — RUNNING

› Build a pomodoro timer as a single HTML file. Start, pause and reset, a 25/5 minute cycle, and a sound at the end.

Creating the timer: start, pause, reset and a 25/5 cycle.

talk-time — RUNNING

› Write a Node.js script that estimates the speaking time of every slide in .demo/slides. Don't change any files in .demo.

Let me look at the slides in `.demo/slides` first.

09:17 Watching an agent feels unproductive.

1 RUNNING 1 WAITING 1 DONE 3 SWITCHES

me — IDLE 13M

› Write the intro of my talk.

"The AI chaos beast in your head"

pomodoro — DONE

› Build a pomodoro timer as a single HTML file. Start, pause and reset, a 25/5 minute cycle, and a sound at the end.

Done. Open `index.html` in a browser.

talk-time — RUNNING

› Write a Node.js script that estimates the speaking time of every slide in .demo/slides. Don't change any files in .demo.

Found 8 markdown files. Stripping the `<style>` blocks first.

todo — NEEDS INPUT

› I want a to-do app. Before you write any code, ask me which framework and storage I want, and wait for my answer.

Before I write any code, I need two decisions from you.

09:24 It has a question. I'll answer it later.

1 RUNNING 1 WAITING 2 DONE 4 SWITCHES

me — IDLE 20M

› Write the intro of my talk.

"The AI chaos beast in your head"

pomodoro — DONE

› Build a pomodoro timer as a single HTML file. Start, pause and reset, a 25/5 minute cycle, and a sound at the end.

Done. Open `index.html` in a browser.

talk-time — DONE

› Write a Node.js script that estimates the speaking time of every slide in .demo/slides. Don't change any files in .demo.

Created `index.mjs`. I did not change any files in `.demo`.

todo — WAITING 7M

› I want a to-do app. Before you write any code, ask me which framework and storage I want, and wait for my answer.

Before I write any code, I need two decisions from you.

focus-tip — RUNNING

› Create a tiny CLI that prints a random focus tip for developers. At least 20 tips and an --all flag.

Collecting 20 focus tips for developers…

09:31 Let me document all of this.

1 RUNNING 1 WAITING 3 DONE 5 SWITCHES

me — IDLE 27M

› Write the intro of my talk.

"The AI chaos beast in your head"

pomodoro — DONE

› Build a pomodoro timer as a single HTML file. Start, pause and reset, a 25/5 minute cycle, and a sound at the end.

Done. Open `index.html` in a browser.

talk-time — DONE

› Write a Node.js script that estimates the speaking time of every slide in .demo/slides. Don't change any files in .demo.

Created `index.mjs`. I did not change any files in `.demo`.

todo — WAITING 14M

› I want a to-do app. Before you write any code, ask me which framework and storage I want, and wait for my answer.

Before I write any code, I need two decisions from you.

focus-tip — DONE

› Create a tiny CLI that prints a random focus tip for developers. At least 20 tips and an --all flag.

Tip #1: Run one agent at a time.

readme — RUNNING

› Create a README for playground that explains each folder. Check the other folders first, some might still be in progress.

`todo` is empty. That session is waiting for an answer.

09:36 Now my agent is managing me.

0 RUNNING 1 WAITING 4 DONE 6 SWITCHES

me — IDLE 32M

› Write the intro of my talk.

"The AI chaos beast in your head"

pomodoro — DONE

› Build a pomodoro timer as a single HTML file. Start, pause and reset, a 25/5 minute cycle, and a sound at the end.

Done. Open `index.html` in a browser.

talk-time — DONE

› Write a Node.js script that estimates the speaking time of every slide in .demo/slides. Don't change any files in .demo.

Created `index.mjs`. I did not change any files in `.demo`.

todo — WAITING 19M

› I want a to-do app. Before you write any code, ask me which framework and storage I want, and wait for my answer.

Before I write any code, I need two decisions from you.

focus-tip — DONE

› Create a tiny CLI that prints a random focus tip for developers. At least 20 tips and an --all flag.

Tip #1: Run one agent at a time.

readme — DONE

› Create a README for playground that explains each folder. Check the other folders first, some might still be in progress.

README · JUST NOW

You might want to answer the question in the to-do session. It is still waiting for you.

09:40 Pop quiz.

0 RUNNING 1 WAITING 4 DONE 6 SWITCHES

Which one needs my attention?

09:40 The to-do app. Waiting 23 minutes for two answers.

me · IDLE 36M

› Write the intro of my talk.

"The AI chaos beast in your head"

pomodoro · DONE

› Build a pomodoro timer as a single HTML file. Start, pause and reset, a 25/5 minute cycle, and a sound at the end.

Done. Open `index.html` in a browser.

talk-time · DONE

› Write a Node.js script that estimates the speaking time of every slide in .demo/slides. Don't change any files in .demo.

Created `index.mjs`. I did not change any files in `.demo`.

todo · WAITING 23M

› I want a to-do app. Before you write any code, ask me which framework and storage I want, and wait for my answer.

Before I write any code, I need two decisions from you.

focus-tip · DONE

› Create a tiny CLI that prints a random focus tip for developers. At least 20 tips and an --all flag.

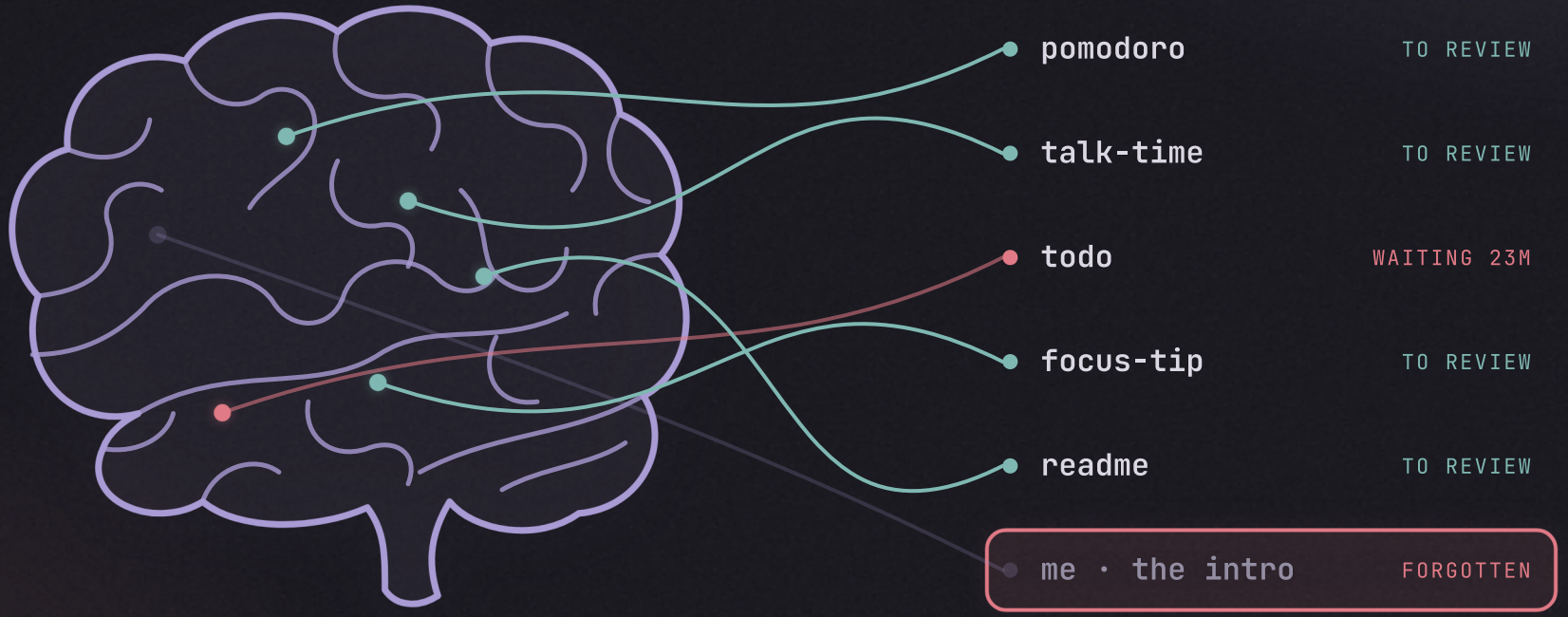
Tip #1: Run one agent at a time.

readme · DONE

› Create a README for playground that explains each folder. Check the other folders first, some might still be in progress.

Created `README.md`. Marked `todo` as blocked.

09:40 Six open threads. I forgot the one I sat down to do.



// context switch

Notes became agents

FOCUSED

Before AI

- Plan the day
- One task, hours of focus
- New idea? Write it down
- Back to the task

OVERLOADED

Today

- Plan the day
- Start an agent
- New idea? Start another agent
- And another one...

4 to 5 agents at once

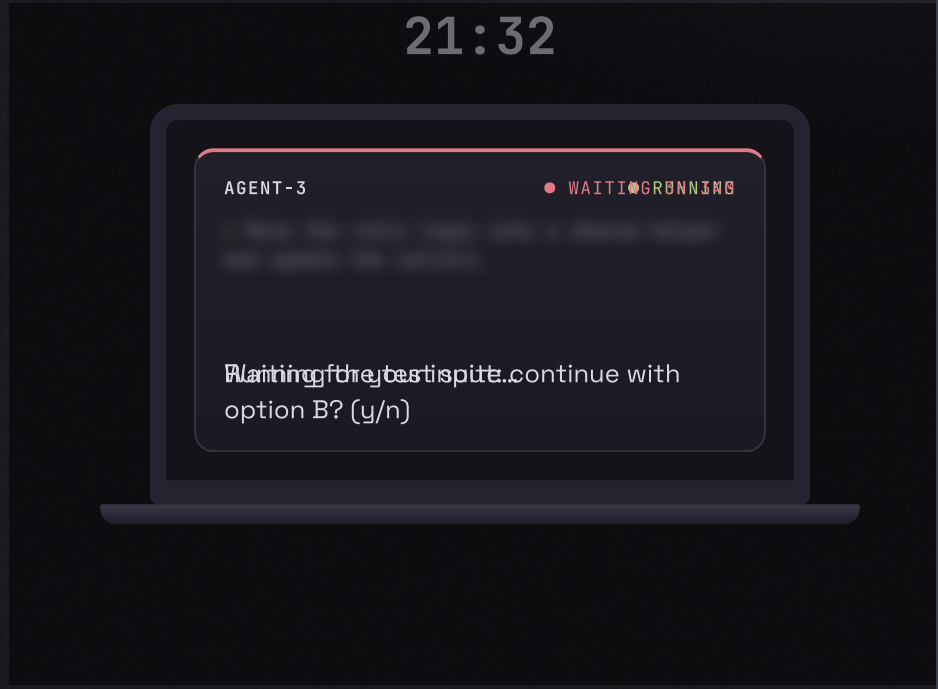
Every wait became a new task.

Every task became a context switch.

The forgotten agent

- Agents running at the end of the day
- Laptop closed, went home
- Opened it again that evening
- An agent was still waiting for my input

I had no idea why I started it.



Open loops

- Before: one mail, one reply, done
- Today: one summary, ten open tasks at 9am
- Every running agent is another open loop

Our brain needs closure to rest.

CLOSED LOOP

Make your bed

- One small task
- Clearly finished
- A small win to start the day

OPEN LOOPS

Open your AI summary

- Ten open tasks
- Nothing finished yet
- Anxiety to start the day

src ▸ McRaven, UT Austin, 2014 · Amabile and Kramer, The Progress Principle, 2011

AI made us move so fast that we run faster than we actually can.

// context switch

What happens in your brain

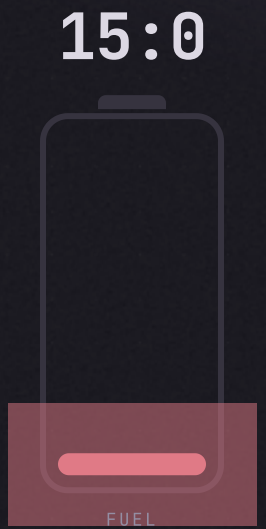
Every time you shift your attention from one thing to another, the brain has to engage a neurochemical switch that uses up nutrients in the brain

Daniel Levitin, neuroscientist

Switching burns fuel

- Every switch burns oxygenated glucose in the prefrontal cortex
- The same fuel you need to stay on task
- *"We have a limited supply of that stuff."*

Five agents means constant switching. That's why you're empty by 3pm.



SWITCHES 480

src ▸ Daniel Levitin, The Organized Mind, 2014

One hour of work

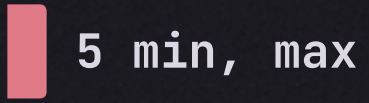
Mails, chat, social media, notifications. And that was before AI agents.

src ▸ Gloria Mark, University of California, Irvine, via Manoush Zomorodi, TED2017

The longest focus session

Before AI one task, hours of focus

Today writing the prompt



Stress makes it worse

- Multitasking raises **cortisol** and **adrenaline**
- *"When people are stressed, they tend to shift their attention more rapidly."*
- More switching, more stress. A loop.

src ▸ Daniel Levitin, 2015 · Gloria Mark, via TED2017

> Little decisions appear to take up as much energy as big ones.

Daniel Levitin. Approve. Reject. Re-prompt. Every agent asks you to decide.

> Multitasking creates a dopamine-addiction feedback loop, effectively rewarding the brain for losing focus.

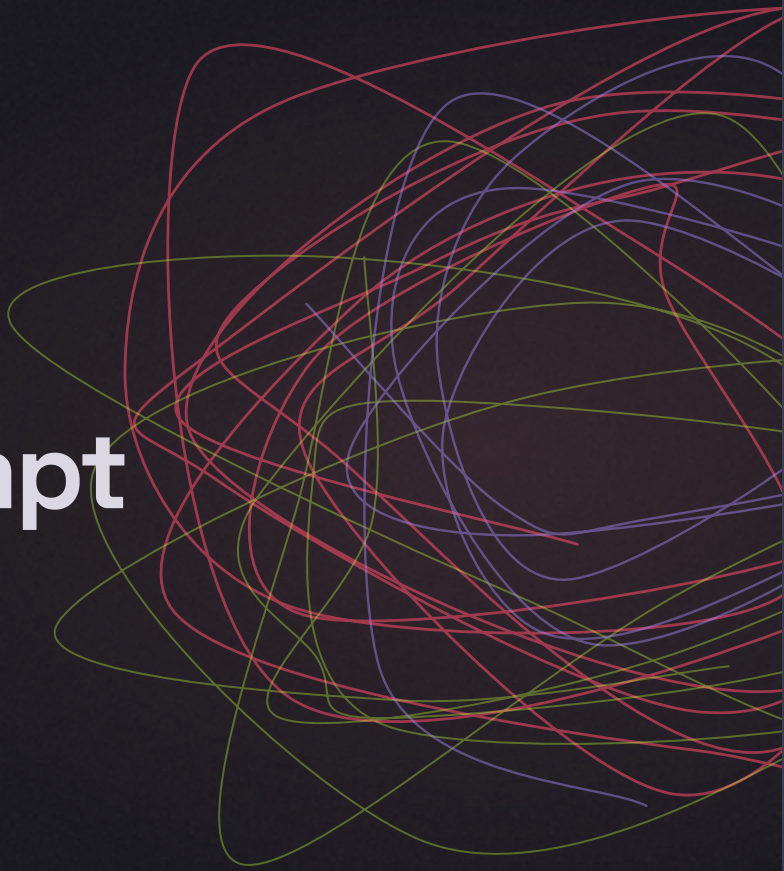
Daniel Levitin

// context switch

And AI gives you that dopamine hit every time it completes a task for you

// context switch

Just one more prompt



The loop

01. New idea
02. First prompt works
03. ”Add this”
04. ”Oh, and that”
05. **It’s 11pm**

Why we don’t wait

- Watching an agent feels unproductive
- The brain starts planning the next prompt
- Starting a new agent feels better than waiting

Every prompt feels like progress.
But are we actually faster?

PERCEIVED

Feeling faster (2025)

Developers expected AI to make them **24% faster**.

Afterwards, they felt **20% faster**.

MEASURED

Being faster (2025)

They were measured **19% slower**.

src ▸ METR randomized trial, 16 experienced developers, early-2025 tools

The gap

src ▸ METR randomized trial, 16 experienced developers, early-2025 tools

PERCEIVED

Feeling faster (2026)

Technical workers now report **3x faster**.

MEASURED

Being faster (2026)

Better tools, new study: maybe **4 to 18% faster**.

Many developers refused to join.
They didn't want to work without AI.

src ▸ METR follow-up, 57 developers, late-2025 tools (Feb 2026). METR survey, 349 technical workers (May 2026).

2025

AI in the editor

- I gave it the context
- I ran the tests
- I explained it again, every time

2026

Agents

- They search the codebase
- They run the tests and try again
- Instruction files and memory: told once

src ▸ What changed for me. METR doesn't say why the numbers moved.

Faster, yes. Just not as fast as it feels.

That gap is where "just one more prompt" comes from.

// context switch

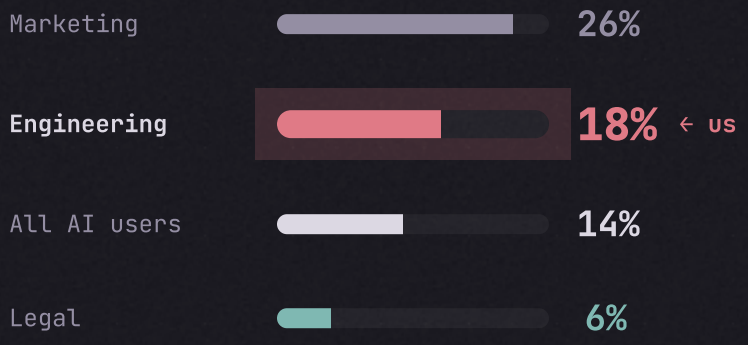
It’s not just me

AI brain fry

Mental fatigue from using or overseeing AI tools beyond your cognitive capacity.

1 in 7

AI users reported it



src ▸ BCG / Harvard Business Review, March 2026 · 1,488 full-time US workers · self-reported

More tools, less output

AI TOOLS	PRODUCTIVITY
1 to 2	↑ Clear jump
3	↗ Smaller gain
4+	↘ Starts to decline

src ▸ BCG / Harvard Business Review, March 2026

The cost

- **33%** more decision fatigue
- **39%** more major errors
- Higher intent to quit

src ▸ BCG / Harvard Business Review, March 2026

What happens to our skills?

- More trust in AI means less critical thinking
- People skip checking when they can’t judge the output

src ▸ Microsoft Research and Carnegie Mellon, CHI 2025, 319 knowledge workers

SHIPPED

My Swift app

- I don’t know Swift
- Never wrote a line of it
- I use it every day

LEARNED

What I learned

Nothing.

Idea to product in a couple of hours.

Early signs from brain research

- Passive use may weaken learning over time
- Active use may keep it sharp
- Still a hypothesis, needs long-term studies

src ▸ Rossi, Fraccaro and Manzotti, npj Artificial Intelligence, January 2026

// context switch

Voices from the field

> AI can generate work faster than you can develop an opinion about it.

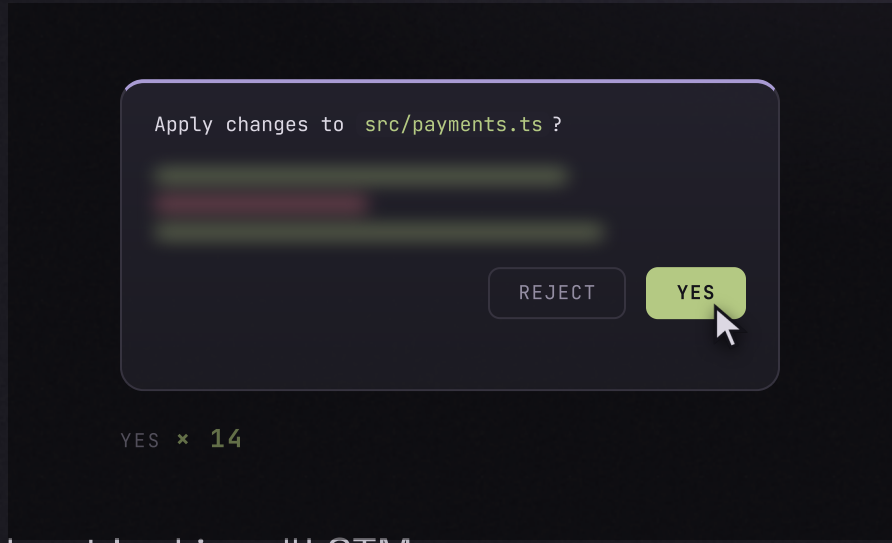
Philipp Pohlmann, ML6

The autopilot in numbers

31% of conversations: the AI proposes a change

92% of those get a human decision

95% of those decisions: yes



*People get desensitised and click yes without looking. #LGTM

”It looked the same, but nothing worked.”

- The loop said it was done. It wasn’t.
- Ask for one change, get two.
- AI output nobody reads.

Coding loops feel like feeding a seven-headed dragon.

src ▸ Petra Tant, Aprimo

1.4k items

Shipped in one month. Marketing and customers couldn't keep up.
Maarten De Schuymer, Aikido Security

> When building gets cheap, focus gets expensive.

Matti Desmet, Peripass

// context switch

The pressure from above

”Would this fit in the next release?”

01. Manager asks AI
02. AI says yes
03. Developers get the request
04. Nobody checked the architecture or the impact

voxium
@v0xium

I am done with this shit. It is over. The state of engineering right now is horrible. It has been half a month since I started a new role at a big company. Nobody knows anything here. The specs, code, tests, PRDs, tickets, resolution of those tickets, reports, etc., everything is made by Claude Code. Nobody on my team likes this. They are being forced to ship as much as they can. I have heard multiple times from higher management that pushing code is not a bottleneck, so why are we slow? People are working 12 to 13 hours a day just to press enter. Nobody is reading anything. Humans in corporate are doing nothing on their own. Everyone, literally everyone, from an L1 to an L7 engineer here is doing the same thing. Talk to Claude. There is no sense of victory. Nobody is resolving bugs. In reality, nobody is thinking anymore. Everything is done by LLMs. It is so soul-sucking. I would not mind it, to be honest, if we were at least given the time to check out the code and see what is going where. But no, the goal is to just ship. No matter what happens.

> Writing code by hand is no longer an economically productive enterprise for the vast majority of programmers working at the vast majority of companies.

David Heinemeier Hansson, Rails World 2026

1,9,257 lines of code in 11 days

One developer. 6,778 commits. Directed, not written.

Who keeps that in their head?

src ▸ Paul Dix, "The End of Programming", August 2026

Writing code is no longer the bottleneck.

My brain is.

Built around humans?

Our 8-hour workday was designed around human focus.

Running 5 agents at once was never part of that design.

“

We're doing robot work,
but we’re not robots.

// context switch

So, AI is the problem?

“

AI is helping me, but I’m not helping myself with AI.

It’s how we use it

- AI doesn’t start the fifth agent. I do.
- AI doesn’t say ”one more thing.” I do.
- The tools removed the friction that used to stop us.

// context switch

What I tried

EXPERIMENT

Play a game while waiting

- Less drained
- No ”what’s next” thinking

SIDE EFFECTS

The catch

- Felt disconnected from the work
- Needed time to get back in
- Or just started prompting again

Just wait?

While I watch, my brain plans the next prompt.

Before I know it, I start another agent anyway.

We became afraid of silence.

> Our body, it goes on autopilot while we're folding the laundry or we're walking to work, but actually that is when our brain gets really busy.

Manoush Zomorodi, TED2017

WORKS

The bike

Body on autopilot.

Mind free to wander.

DOESN'T

The game

Fills the space.

No room left to think.

// context switch

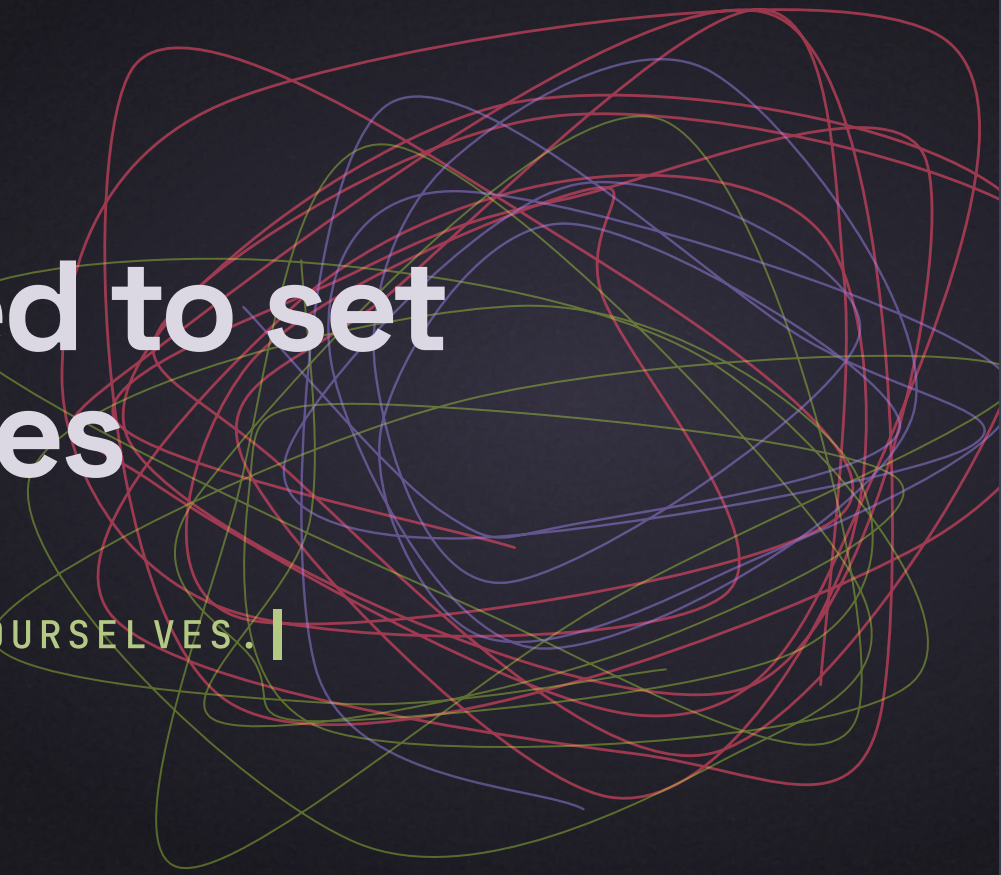
My boundaries

Boundaries, not against AI

01. **Fewer parallel agents** - two or three I can follow
02. **A ”later” list** - write the idea down, don’t start an agent
03. **Stay in the loop** - ask what it did and why
04. **Real breaks** - away from the screen
05. **A hard stop** - ”one more thing” means close the laptop

The work used to set the boundaries

$ NOW WE HAVE TO SET THEM OURSELVES.



// context switch

You’re not alone

If you recognize yourself

- The constant prompting
- The pressure to deliver faster and more
- The chaos in your head

It’s not just you.

Let the agents run. Take your breaks.

Fast is fine. Stopping is a skill.

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Thank you

$ SLIDES AND RESOURCES:
ENGAGETIME.LIVE/SESSION/4YFRVP